**Prohibition of Arms** Entering into the neighbourhood of a polling station with any kind of arms is to be considered a cognizable offence. But, these provisions are not applicable to the returning officer, presiding officer, any police officer or any other person appointed to maintain peace and order at the polling station.

**Effective Campaigning Period Reduced** The minimum gap between the last date for withdrawal of candidature and the polling date has been reduced from 20 to 14 days.

**ELECTORAL REFORMS AFTER 1996**

**Presidential and Vice Presidential Elections** In 1997[8], the number of electors as proposers and seconders for contesting election to the office of the President was increased from 10 to 50 and to the office of the Vice President from 5 to 20. Further, the amount of security deposit was increased from ₹2,500 to ₹15,000 for contesting election to both the offices of President and Vice-President to discourage frivolous candidates.

**Requisitioning of Staff for Election Duty** In 1998[9], a provision was made whereby the employees of local authorities, nationalised banks, universities, LIC, government undertakings and other government-aided institutions can be requisitioned for deployment on election duty.

**Voting through Postal Ballot** In 1999[10], a provision was made for voting by certain classes of persons through postal ballot. Thus, any class of persons can be notified by the Election Commission, in consultation with the government, and the persons belonging to such notified class can give their votes by postal ballot, and not in any other manner, at elections in their constituency or constituencies.

**Facility to Opt to Vote Through Proxy** In 2003[11], the facility to opt to vote through proxy was provided to the service voters belonging to the Armed Forces and members belonging to a Force to which provisions of the Army Act apply. Such service voters who opt to vote through proxy have to appoint a proxy in a prescribed format and intimate the Returning Officer of the constituency.

**Declaration of Criminal Antecedents, Assets, etc., by Candidates** In 2003, the election Commission issued an order directing every candidate seeking election to the Parliament or a State Legislature to furnish on his/her nomination paper the information on the following matters.

1. Whether the candidate has been convicted or acquitted or discharged in any criminal offence in the past? Whether he/she was imprisoned or fined?

2. Prior to six months of filing nomination, whether the candidate is accused of any pending case, of any offence punishable with imprisonment for two years or more, and in which charges were framed or cognizance was taken by a court; if so, the details thereof

3. The assets (immovable, movable, bank balances, etc.) of a candidate and his/her spouse and that of dependents

4. Liabilities, if any, particularly whether there are any dues of any public financial institution or government dues

5. The educational qualifications of the candidate

Furnishing of any false information in the affidavit is now an electoral offence.